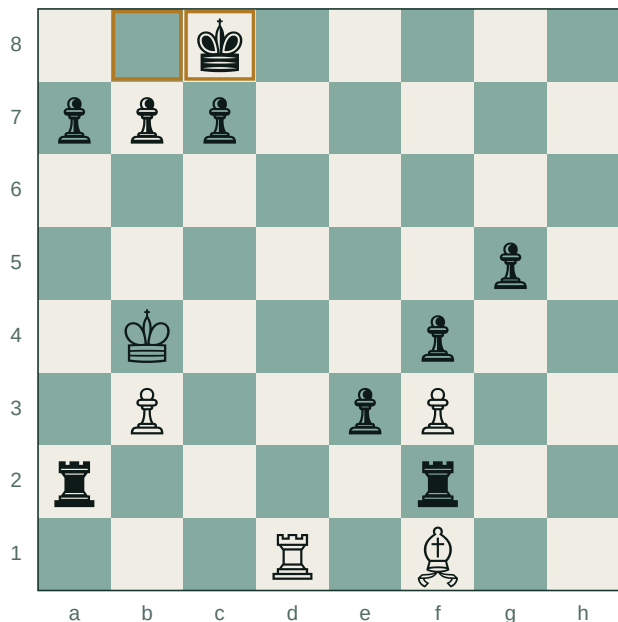


# Back-rank mates: White, move 34

Back-rank mates

White to move



Previous move: 33...Kc8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

**WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST**

**34. Bh3+ g4 35. Bxg4+ Kb8 36. Rd8#**

**34.Bh3+** Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **34...g4**.

**35.Bxg4+** Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the pawn on g4. Recorded reply: **35...Kb8**.

**36.Rd8#** Mate: rook on d8 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on b8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

**CHECKPOINT**

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on d8. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

**CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES**

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.

**WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES**

A king trapped behind its own pawns may have no flight square when a rook or queen reaches its back rank. The entry square and its defenders are critical.

**HOW TO LOOK**

Inspect the king's pawn shelter, then find how a heavy piece can enter the last rank or remove its defender.

The defending king is on c8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.